

CBT WORKBOOK FOR ANXIETY

Evidence-Based Exercises to Calm Your Mind

A Practical Guide with Worksheets,
Thought Records & Behavioral Experiments

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Licensed CBT Techniques for Self-Help

CBT Workbook for Anxiety

Evidence-Based Exercises to Calm Your Mind

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This workbook is for educational purposes only.

It is not a substitute for professional mental health treatment.

If you are in crisis, call 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.

CHAPTER 1: WHAT IS CBT?

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) is an evidence-based psychological treatment that has been proven effective for anxiety disorders.

The core principle of CBT is that our THOUGHTS affect our FEELINGS, which in turn affect our BEHAVIORS. By changing unhelpful thought patterns, we can reduce anxiety and improve our quality of life.

THE CBT TRIANGLE:

THOUGHTS (what we think)

|

FEELINGS (what we feel emotionally and physically)

|

BEHAVIORS (what we do or avoid)

HOW THIS WORKBOOK WORKS:

1. You will learn to IDENTIFY your anxious thoughts
2. You will EXAMINE the evidence for and against these thoughts
3. You will CHALLENGE cognitive distortions
4. You will CREATE balanced, realistic alternatives
5. You will EXPERIMENT with new behaviors

CBT is not about positive thinking - it is about REALISTIC thinking. You will learn to evaluate your thoughts like a scientist, testing hypotheses rather than accepting anxious predictions as facts.

Understanding what triggers your anxiety is the first step to managing it.

List your top anxiety triggers below:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____

For each trigger, rate intensity (1-10):

[illegible]

THOUGHT RECORD - Page 1

Date: _____ Time: _____ Situation: _____

SITUATION	AUTOMATIC	EMOTION	EVIDENCE	BALANCED
(What happened?)	THOUGHT	(0-100%)	FOR/AGAINST	THOUGHT

What I learned from this thought record:

New behavior I will try based on my balanced thought:

THOUGHT RECORD - Page 2

Date: _____ Time: _____ Situation: _____

SITUATION	AUTOMATIC	EMOTION	EVIDENCE	BALANCED
(What happened?)	THOUGHT	(0-100%)	FOR/AGAINST	THOUGHT

What I learned from this thought record:

New behavior I will try based on my balanced thought:

THOUGHT RECORD - Page 3

Date: _____ Time: _____ Situation: _____

SITUATION (What happened?)	AUTOMATIC THOUGHT	EMOTION (0-100%)	EVIDENCE FOR/AGAINST	BALANCED THOUGHT

What I learned from this thought record:

New behavior I will try based on my balanced thought:

THOUGHT RECORD - Page 4

Date: _____ Time: _____ Situation: _____

SITUATION	AUTOMATIC	EMOTION	EVIDENCE	BALANCED
(What happened?)	THOUGHT	(0-100%)	FOR/AGAINST	THOUGHT

What I learned from this thought record:

New behavior I will try based on my balanced thought:

THOUGHT RECORD - Page 5

Date: _____ Time: _____ Situation: _____

SITUATION	AUTOMATIC	EMOTION	EVIDENCE	BALANCED
(What happened?)	THOUGHT	(0-100%)	FOR/AGAINST	THOUGHT

What I learned from this thought record:

New behavior I will try based on my balanced thought:

10 COMMON COGNITIVE DISTORTIONS

1. All-or-Nothing Thinking

Seeing things in black-and-white. Example: 'If I'm not perfect, I'm a failure.'

2. Catastrophizing

Expecting the worst outcome. Example: 'This headache must be a brain tumor.'

3. Mind Reading

Assuming you know what others think. Example: 'They think I'm stupid.'

4. Fortune Telling

Predicting negative outcomes. Example: 'I'll definitely fail the interview.'

5. Emotional Reasoning

Feelings = facts. Example: 'I feel anxious, so something bad will happen.'

6. Should Statements

Rigid rules. Example: 'I should never make mistakes.'

7. Labeling

Defining self by one event. Example: 'I'm a loser' after one setback.

8. Magnification/Minimization

Blowing up negatives, shrinking positives.

9. Overgeneralization

One event = always. Example: 'I always mess things up.'

10. Personalization

Blaming yourself for everything. Example: 'It's all my fault.'

CHALLENGING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS - Exercise 1

My anxious thought:

Evidence SUPPORTING this thought:

Evidence AGAINST this thought:

Which cognitive distortion is at play?

What would I tell a friend with this thought?

My balanced, realistic alternative thought:

How much do I believe the original thought now? (0-100%): _____

Emotion intensity now (0-100%): _____

CHALLENGING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS - Exercise 2

My anxious thought:

Evidence SUPPORTING this thought:

Evidence AGAINST this thought:

Which cognitive distortion is at play?

What would I tell a friend with this thought?

My balanced, realistic alternative thought:

How much do I believe the original thought now? (0-100%): _____

Emotion intensity now (0-100%): _____

CHALLENGING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS - Exercise 3

My anxious thought:

Evidence SUPPORTING this thought:

Evidence AGAINST this thought:

Which cognitive distortion is at play?

What would I tell a friend with this thought?

My balanced, realistic alternative thought:

How much do I believe the original thought now? (0-100%): _____

Emotion intensity now (0-100%): _____

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT PLANNER - #1

Anxious prediction (what I think will happen):

How strongly I believe this (0-100%):

The experiment (what I will do to test this):

When and where:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

Belief in prediction now (0-100%):

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT PLANNER - #2

Anxious prediction (what I think will happen):

How strongly I believe this (0-100%):

The experiment (what I will do to test this):

When and where:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

Belief in prediction now (0-100%):

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT PLANNER - #3

Anxious prediction (what I think will happen):

How strongly I believe this (0-100%):

The experiment (what I will do to test this):

When and where:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

Belief in prediction now (0-100%):

EXPOSURE HIERARCHY WORKSHEET - Page 1

List feared situations from LEAST to MOST anxiety-provoking (SUDS 0-100):

SUDS	Feared Situation	Date Attempted
10		
20		
30		
40		
50		
60		
70		
80		
90		
100		

EXPOSURE HIERARCHY WORKSHEET - Page 2

List feared situations from LEAST to MOST anxiety-provoking (SUDS 0-100):

SUDS	Feared Situation	Date Attempted
10		
20		
30		
40		
50		
60		
70		
80		
90		
100		

[illegible]

BREATHING EXERCISES

THE 4-7-8 TECHNIQUE (Dr. Andrew Weil)

1. Exhale completely through your mouth, making a whoosh sound.
2. Close your mouth and inhale quietly through your nose for 4 counts.
3. Hold your breath for 7 counts.
4. Exhale completely through your mouth for 8 counts.
5. This is one breath cycle. Repeat 3 more times (4 cycles total).

Practice twice daily. It becomes more effective with repetition.

BOX BREATHING (Navy SEAL Technique)

1. Breathe IN for 4 counts
2. HOLD for 4 counts
3. Breathe OUT for 4 counts
4. HOLD for 4 counts

Repeat 4-6 cycles.

DIAPHRAGMATIC BREATHING

1. Place one hand on chest, one on belly.
2. Breathe in slowly - only belly hand should rise.
3. Exhale slowly - belly falls. Chest stays still.
4. Practice 5-10 minutes daily.

WORRY TIME SCHEDULING

Designate 15-20 minutes daily as your 'worry time.'

Outside this time, write worries down and postpone them.

My designated worry time: _____ to _____

Location: _____

TODAY'S WORRY LIST:

Worry	Can I control it?	Action step
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

After worry time, rate your anxiety (1-10): _____

Did any worries feel less important by worry time? (circle) YES / NO

Safety behaviors are things we do to prevent feared outcomes. They maintain anxiety by preventing us from learning the truth.

MY SAFETY BEHAVIORS:

[illegible]

GRADED EXPOSURE LADDER

My feared situation: _____

Build steps from EASIEST (bottom) to HARDEST (top):

10.	_____	SUDS: _____
9.	_____	SUDS: _____
8.	_____	SUDS: _____
7.	_____	SUDS: _____
6.	_____	SUDS: _____
5.	_____	SUDS: _____
4.	_____	SUDS: _____
3.	_____	SUDS: _____
2.	_____	SUDS: _____
1.	_____	SUDS: _____

Start at step 1. Move up only when SUDS drops to 3 or below.

WEEKLY MOOD TRACKER - Week 1

Rate each item 1-10 daily:

Day	Anxiety	Mood	Sleep	Exercise	Social	CBT Done?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Week’s biggest challenge:

Week’s biggest win:

What I will do differently next week:

WEEKLY MOOD TRACKER - Week 2

Rate each item 1-10 daily:

Day	Anxiety	Mood	Sleep	Exercise	Social	CBT Done?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Week’s biggest challenge:

Week’s biggest win:

What I will do differently next week:

WEEKLY MOOD TRACKER - Week 3

Rate each item 1-10 daily:

Day	Anxiety	Mood	Sleep	Exercise	Social	CBT Done?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Week’s biggest challenge:

Week’s biggest win:

What I will do differently next week:

WEEKLY MOOD TRACKER - Week 4

Rate each item 1-10 daily:

Day	Anxiety	Mood	Sleep	Exercise	Social	CBT Done?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Week’s biggest challenge:

Week’s biggest win:

What I will do differently next week:

RELAPSE PREVENTION PLAN

My early warning signs that anxiety is returning:

My known triggers:

CBT skills that work best for me:

My coping statements:

People I can reach out to:

Professional support contacts:

My self-care non-negotiables:

If I notice a setback, I will:

30-DAY CBT CHALLENGE

Complete one challenge each day. Check off when done.

- ☐ Day 1: Write down 3 anxious thoughts you had today
- ☐ Day 2: Identify the cognitive distortion in each thought
- ☐ Day 3: Practice 4-7-8 breathing 3 times today
- ☐ Day 4: Complete one full thought record
- ☐ Day 5: List 5 things you are avoiding due to anxiety
- ☐ Day 6: Do one thing from your avoidance list (easiest)
- ☐ Day 7: Practice progressive muscle relaxation
- ☐ Day 8: Challenge one 'should' statement
- ☐ Day 9: Write evidence for AND against your biggest worry
- ☐ Day 10: Set up your daily worry time
- ☐ Day 11: Notice and record 3 safety behaviors
- ☐ Day 12: Drop one safety behavior today
- ☐ Day 13: Practice box breathing before a stressful event
- ☐ Day 14: Complete a behavioral experiment
- ☐ Day 15: MID-POINT CHECK-IN - Rate anxiety now vs Day 1
- ☐ Day 16: Practice 'observe without judgment' for 5 min
- ☐ Day 17: Write a compassionate letter to your anxious self
- ☐ Day 18: Identify your #1 core belief driving anxiety
- ☐ Day 19: Create a coping card for your worst situation
- ☐ Day 20: Practice accepting uncertainty for one decision
- ☐ Day 21: Do something fun you've been avoiding
- ☐ Day 22: Challenge a fortune-telling thought
- ☐ Day 23: Practice saying 'I notice I'm having the thought...'
- ☐ Day 24: Move up one step on your exposure ladder
- ☐ Day 25: Teach someone else one CBT technique
- ☐ Day 26: Review all your thought records - find patterns
- ☐ Day 27: Update your relapse prevention plan
- ☐ Day 28: Practice gratitude - write 5 things
- ☐ Day 29: Celebrate your progress - write what changed
- ☐ Day 30: Set 3 CBT goals for the next month